Strategies of Contestation: International Law, Domestic Audiences, and Image Management

Julia C. Morse, University of California, Santa Barbara
Tyler Pratt, Yale University

International relations scholars frequently argue that violations of international law generate political costs for governments. Yet we know little about whether governments can evade responsibility for noncompliance, which may be a low-salience issue for domestic audiences. We propose a theory of image management whereby leaders strategically contest international law violations to influence citizen perceptions of the government. Drawing on communications scholarship, we disaggregate government image into four underlying dimensions: morality, performance, lawfulness, and allegiance. A government's response to violations is designed to influence the dimensions of image valued by its political coalition. We develop a typology of response strategies and test their effects in a survey experiment examining violations of the torture, trade, and chemical weapons regimes. Our results offer fresh insights for compliance scholarship. Governments can mitigate backlash and leverage allegations of noncompliance for political ends, but their strategies are constrained by the foreign policy preferences of supporters.

In November 2017, a prosecutor for the International Criminal Court (ICC) requested a formal investigation into allegations of US war crimes in Afghanistan. As the ICC-Pre-trial Chamber considered the request, the Trump administration launched an aggressive campaign to denounce the court. Speaking to the Federalist Society in Washington, DC, National Security Advisor John Bolton vowed to "use any means necessary to protect our citizens . . . from unjust prosecution by this illegitimate court" (Bowcott, Holmes, and Durkin 2018). When the ICC moved forward with the investigation, the Trump administration responded even more forcefully, decrying the ICC's actions and authorizing sanctions against ICC officials. Secretary of State Pompeo pledged that "we will not stand by as our people are threatened by a kangaroo court" (DeYoung and Morello 2020).

The Trump administration's response to the ICC shows that even a populist government with a clear aversion to international cooperation can feel compelled to respond to an alleged violation of international law. The United States has a history of fraught engagement with the ICC, and the Trump administration could have chosen to downplay the investigation. Yet it elevated the issue, publicly attacking the ICC and issuing unprecedented sanctions.

The form and content of the Trump administration's response is also noteworthy. US officials not only challenged the court's legitimacy, they used the ICC investigation to bolster the Trump administration's image as a protector of American citizens. This strategy contrasts with the approaches of previous administrations that confronted similar allegations. In the early 2000s, the Bush administration defended abusive interrogation methods against suspected terrorists with a strategy of "legal evasion": reinterpreting international torture rules to argue that its actions were consistent with international law (Sanders 2011). Years later, the Obama administration justified its decision to decline prosecution of Bush-era interrogators by arguing that a lack of criminal prosecution is not a moral exoneration (Shane 2012).

US officials' varied responses to torture allegations are part of a larger story about the link between international law and domestic politics. International relations scholars often

Julia C. Morse (jcmorse@polsci.ucsb.edu) is an assistant professor at the University of California, Santa Barbara, Goleta, CA 93106. Tyler Pratt (tyler.pratt@yale.edu) is an assistant professor at Yale University, New Haven, CT 06520.

The survey experiment in this article was preregistered with Evidence in Governance and Politics in May 2020. Replication files are available in the *JOP* Dataverse (https://dataverse.harvard.edu/dataverse/jop). The empirical analysis has been successfully replicated by the *JOP* replication analyst. An appendix with supplementary material is available at https://doi.org/10.1086/719418.

Published online August 4, 2022.

The Journal of Politics, volume 84, number 4, October 2022. © 2022 Southern Political Science Association. All rights reserved. Published by The University of Chicago Press for the Southern Political Science Association. https://doi.org/10.1086/719418

posit that domestic and international backlash can encourage compliance with international rules. In the domestic arena, much of this work focuses on how interest groups and civil society organizations mobilize to support compliance or discipline governments that fail to meet their obligations (Dai 2007; Keck and Sikkink 1998; Simmons 2009). Others argue that international law has a direct effect on public opinion (Chaudoin 2014; Kreps and Wallace 2016; Wallace 2013), leading constituents to punish their government for noncompliance (Kim 2019b; Lupu and Wallace 2019).

Yet both international rules and government responsibility are subject to significant interpretational ambiguity. Governments do not simply passively accept allegations of noncompliance; rather, they offer public defenses designed to mitigate political costs. Recent work demonstrates that how governments frame their behavior and justify violations can affect public opinion (Brutger and Kertzer 2018; Chu 2019; Strezhnev, Simmons, and Kim 2019; Zvobgo 2019).

We argue that governmental responses to alleged international law violations are best understood as part of a broader strategy of image management. A government's public image is multidimensional, reflecting citizens' beliefs about different values and abilities. And while high-stakes foreign policy crises may require governments to emphasize specific characteristics like credibility or resolve, less publicized events provide opportunities to craft more varied narratives about behavior. A government's rhetorical defense may be designed to mitigate anticipated backlash against noncompliance, or it might be designed to leverage publicity for other political goals. Just as a cosmopolitan government may want to signal its intention to follow international law in the future, a populist government might use an alleged violation to remind supporters that it looks out for its own citizens first. By conceptualizing a government's response through the lens of image management, we offer an explanation for why governments "pick fights" over international law violations even when the allegation might have otherwise gone unnoticed by many citizens.

Our theory integrates international relations scholarship with insights from public relations and corporate communications. The latter traditions examine how organizations and individuals manage their public images with relevant audiences. Building on existing typologies of image management for organizations (Carpenter 2010), we conceptualize a government's image as composed of four primary traits: moral authority, performance, lawfulness, and allegiance to citizen interests. Transposing these four dimensions to the realm of foreign policy and public opinion provides a more comprehensive account of the political stakes for a government facing a foreign policy crisis. It is rarely possible for a government to shift public opinion on all four dimensions; instead, policy makers face trade-offs that depend on the situation and the underlying values of their supporters.

We apply the concept of image management to the study of international law and public opinion. We offer a typology of persuasive strategies that governments use to justify violating international legal commitments. We distinguish strategies by the degree of antagonism that they exhibit toward the relevant international regime. *Atonement* strategies acknowledge the authority of the international regime and underscore the state's commitment to its international obligations. *Disassociation* strategies shift blame by distancing the government from the violation. *Attack* strategies challenge the legitimacy of international law or portray it as incompatible with national interests.

These strategies shift citizens' beliefs about distinct aspects of the government's image. Atonement strategies, for example, signal a commitment to international law; we therefore expect them to improve the government's image for lawfulness. Attack strategies disparage the regime and reduce the government's lawfulness image but may help bolster perceptions of allegiance to citizens. Finally, disassociation strategies should enhance expectations of future compliance but diminish perceptions of the government's performance. Each strategy's overall effect on public support depends on citizens' underlying values.

We test our argument in a survey experiment examining international law violations across the torture, trade, and chemical weapons regimes. These issue areas vary with respect to normative power and domestic political significance and, thus, contribute to the generalizability of our findings. In a nationally representative survey of American respondents, we show how allegations of international law violations provide opportunities for governments to engage in image management. Across issue areas, rhetorical defenses shift respondent beliefs about different aspects of a government's image. While all strategies translate into higher levels of support for the government, they appeal to distinct audiences with varying foreign policy values.

Our findings have important implications for governmental incentives for compliance, as well as the link between foreign policy rhetoric and public support. We show that many different types of defenses can mitigate—although not completely eliminate—damage to the government's image. Crucially, these overall effects mask meaningful variation among the dimensions of government image and across the citizenry. Scholarship on the domestic mechanisms supporting compliance must grapple with this variation to understand when and how leaders can shirk noncompliance costs.

Our argument also has implications for constructivist work on rhetoric and legitimation. The consequences of noncompliance depend in part on a violation's stigma, which is socially constructed. But in an age where citizens maintain not just different values but separate understandings of basic facts, violations may have polarized impacts. This suggests leaders with antiglobalist supporters will often have domestic political incentives to ignore treaties and even highlight violations, while leaders with cosmopolitan supporters will be more constrained. Global populism may thus pose a prolonged threat to international cooperation, even absent populist leaders.

INTERNATIONAL LAW AND DOMESTIC AUDIENCES

International legal commitments can shape domestic politics through many channels. Domestic interest groups and civil society organizations may mobilize to support compliance on issues like the environment (Dai 2007; Raustiala 1997; Von Stein 2008) and human rights (Hafner-Burton and Tsutsui 2005; Keck and Sikkink 1998; Risse and Sikkink 1999; Simmons 2009).[1] Opposition parties can capitalize on public disapproval of foreign policy actions, using unpopular policy choices to critique a leader's broader executive agenda (Kertzer 2016). International commitments thus shape internal political debate and, in turn, influence how a government translates its policy agenda into law.

International law also affects domestic policy preferences. Kim (2019a) finds that international legal commitments are associated with greater support for compliance among political elites. Others find similar results among domestic constituents, with studies showing international law can shape public support for trade policies (Chaudoin 2014; Powers 2022), refugee admissions (Strezhnev et al. 2019), drone strikes (Kreps and Wallace 2016), treatment of POWs (Chu 2019), solitary confinement (Chilton 2014), government repression (Lupu and Wallace 2019), and the use of torture (Wallace 2013).[2]

Proponents of international cooperation view these findings as promising evidence that violations generate domestic political costs, encouraging governments to comply with their commitments.[3] Existing work varies in the hypothesized mechanisms. International legal commitments may influence citizen value structures (Simmons 2009), while violations may signal a leader is irresponsible (Fang 2008) or shift beliefs about future compliance in other issue areas (Kim 2019b).

Related research on audience costs features similar debates. Audience cost theory argues that citizens punish leaders who renege on public foreign policy commitments (Fearon 1994; Smith 1998; Trager and Vavreck 2011). But there is substantial disagreement regarding the specific inferences that citizens draw when governments "back down." Scholars point to individual views about the importance of the country's national honor or its international reputation or general preferences for consistency between word and deed (Levy et al. 2015; Tomz 2007a). Others suggest citizens are drawing judgments about more specific leader traits such as competence (Levendusky and Horowitz 2012) or belligerence (Kertzer and Brutger 2016). While each of these mechanisms could reduce political support for governments, existing work lacks a unified framework connecting foreign policy commitments to citizens' underlying values and policy preferences.

Theorizing about the effect of international agreements on domestic attitudes is complicated by rule ambiguity and uncertainty. Consider the chain of events that must occur for violations to reduce domestic political support. First, international organizations or other actors must identify and publicly reveal a violation of international rules. Second, constituents must interpret this information in a way that attributes responsibility to the violating state (Mercer 1996). Third, domestic audiences must adjust their beliefs about one or more dispositional characteristics of the noncompliant government. This updating process takes place in a noisy environment with large volumes of potentially competing information.[4] Finally, once beliefs are updated, citizens must adjust their behavior in ways that generate costs for the noncompliant government.

While individual links in this chain have received significant scholarly attention,[5] the process of interpreting violations deserves further scrutiny. Both rationalist and constructivist accounts of belief formation justify a focus on the interpretation stage. Formal models of "cheap talk" communication suggest that citizens' inferences depend on the perceived bias of the actor sending the signal (Crawford

1. Interest groups may also mobilize against international rules (Downs and Rocke 1995; Rosendorff and Milner 2001) or push in both directions (Chaudoin 2016).

2. Although Chilton and Versteeg (2016) find that violation of torture law does not shift public support.

3. This domestic channel complements international reputational effects as a force for sustaining compliance (Keohane 1984; Morrow 2007; Tomz 2007b).

4. Downs and Jones (2002) argue that shifts in beliefs following violations are smaller than commonly believed.

5. Carnegie and Carson (2018) and Terman and Voeten (2018) examine the political incentives associated with revealing violations. Others focus on the mode of information transmission, arguing that ratings and indexes increase political effects (Cooley and Snyder 2015; Kelley 2017; Kelley and Simmons 2015; Morse 2019, 2022).

and Sobel 1982). Governments can contest violations by challenging the impartiality of the international regime or by issuing their own "jamming" messages that contradict the allegation (Minozzi 2011; Minozzi and Woon 2016).

Constructivist accounts highlight how contested social processes give meaning to violations. Scholarship on narrative, legitimation, and norm evasion describes how states use language and ideas to shape reactions to their behavior. Political rhetoric can build support for foreign policy initiatives (Goddard and Krebs 2015; Krebs 2015), and legitimation strategies can reduce backlash against flagrant transgressions. Goddard (2015), for example, describes how Hitler justified German territorial expansion with appeals to shared norms such as self-determination. In other cases, leaders exploit the ambiguity of international law to claim technical compliance even while violating the underlying norm (Búzás 2018). Such theories suggest that the consequences of rule violations depend on how violators respond to the stigma of noncompliance (Adler-Nissen 2014) and how others interpret the noncompliant behavior (Bull 1977; Kratochwil and Ruggie 1986). We build on these and other recent studies that investigate how governments frame their behavior to shape public opinion (Brutger and Kertzer 2018; Chu 2019; Strezhnev et al. 2019; Zvobgo 2019).

A THEORY OF IMAGE MANAGEMENT

The domestic politics of international law violations can be usefully analyzed through the broader lens of governmental image management. Individual attitudes toward a government depend on a citizen's underlying values and beliefs. While allegations of bad behavior can pose a threat to a government's image, they also offer an opportunity for governments to shape individual beliefs about a government's characteristics. A government may refute a violation directly or attempt to shift blame for its behavior. Conversely, it may attack the international rules themselves, using the violation to highlight how the government prioritizes the welfare of its own citizens over international commitments.

We focus our analysis on the period after a state has been accused of noncompliant behavior. We assume that an alleged violation has the potential to affect how citizens view their government; however, the specific direction and nature of this effect will depend on the context of the violation and on citizen preferences. Notably, we do not argue that international law violations are inherently politically salient for domestic audiences. Instead, our theory describes how violations create opportunities for governments to shift perceptions of their underlying strengths and vulnerabilities. Contestation over international law thus becomes a strategy for shaping constituent beliefs about the government.

Allegations of noncompliance trigger a process of image management, visualized in figure 1. First, the government selects among several possible response strategies. A government may apologize for an instance of noncompliance or shift blame to other actors. It can also opt for a strategy of strategic silence, in which the government ignores the allegation in the hopes of minimizing political backlash.

Second, domestic constituents update their assessments of the government. This changes the government's *image*, which we define as perceptions of a government's conduct, motives, and disposition.[6] A key aspect of our conceptualization is that a government's image is multidimensional, reflecting the varied and potentially independent judgments a citizen can reach about different government traits.

Third, citizens have heterogeneous underlying values regarding the "ideal" traits a government should exhibit. Some constituents prioritize competence in carrying out governmental functions, while others place a high weight on honesty or allegiance to citizen interests. These values are likely to be correlated with citizens' political ideology and approach to foreign policy. Fourth, the government's image and citizen values jointly determine the level of domestic political support among constituents. Put simply, citizens vote for political leaders who successfully project an image that they find attractive.

Image management is the process of shaping citizen attitudes to optimize political support. Governments anticipate the chain of events in figure 1, subject to some uncertainty over citizen beliefs and values, and select response strategies accordingly. Governments seek to manage their public image rather than citizen values because the latter are fixed in the short term. Governments can strategically shape the interpretation of key events but will have difficulty manipulating underlying values. Instead, a government focuses on shaping estimates of its own responsibility, the perceived offensiveness of the violation, or other judgments about its behavior (Benoit 2015).

The theoretical process we describe is both parsimonious and adaptable. It unifies two important findings from the literature on international law and domestic politics: the susceptibility of citizens to strategic framing effects and the multidimensional nature of public attitudes regarding foreign policy behavior. As we explain below, the concept of image management opens up significantly more space for political contestation than the traditional constituency-driven domestic compliance mechanism.

6. Benoit (2014, 305) writes that an image is "a perception that develops out of what the organization says or does as well as by what others say about the organization and how others behave toward it."

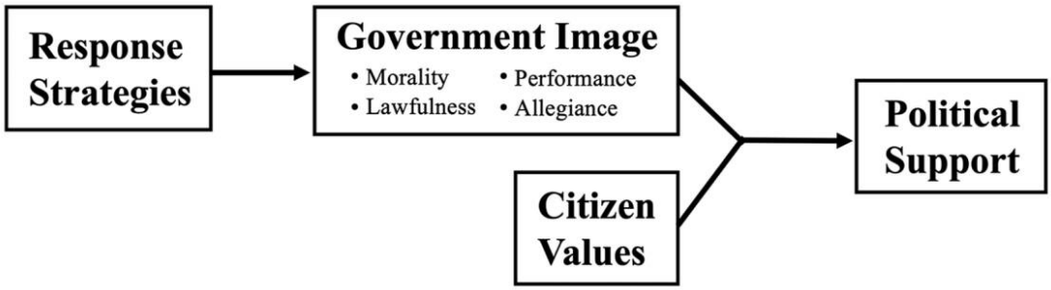

Figure 1. Process of image management following international law violations

Response strategies and framing effects

Governments have political incentives to respond to allegations of international law violations. An allegation may represent a direct threat to a government's image, or it may serve as an opportunity for a government to reinforce select characteristics among key supporters. Regardless of their motivation, governments are not idle observers who passively accept accusations of noncompliance. Instead, they contextualize violations to maximize political support. Policy makers recognize that nonresponse may appear as incompetence or that political opponents may exploit an alleged violation to criticize a leader or the government. Personal factors may also push leaders to respond—individuals usually feel compelled to justify, explain, or defend their behavior (Benoit 2015).[7]

Specific responses will vary across governments; however, even officials with little concern for a country's international reputation often seize the opportunity to craft a compelling narrative. The Trump administration, for example, could have ignored World Trade Organization (WTO) rulings against the United States but instead used them to reinforce its "America first" approach to international policy. When the WTO ruled in favor of China in September 2020, both Trump administration officials and Republican members of Congress publicly criticized the WTO and leveraged the violation to highlight their support for American workers and business (Yu 2020).

Political leaders shape their image by framing violations in ways that appeal to their supporters. Image management is intersubjective; a "smart" rhetorical defense depends on how the speaker perceives the audience's beliefs and underlying values (Benoit 2015, 5). Existing research documents how framing effects—that is, the selective presentation of information to promote "a particular problem definition, causal interpretation, moral evaluation, and/or treatment recommendation" (Entman 1993, 52)—can significantly affect public opinion. Media or elite discourse generates framing effects by emphasizing a subset of relevant considerations, leading individuals to focus on these factors when constructing opinions (Druckman 2001). Foreign policy issues may be particularly subject to framing effects, since political knowledge is often low (Chong and Druckman 2007). Elite messages, however, may have differential effects on public opinion across issue areas (Guisinger and Saunders 2017), and the effect of these messages may depend on individual-level moral values (Brutger 2021; Rathbun 2012; Rathbun and Stein 2020; Rathbun et al. 2016).

A wide range of framing strategies may shift citizen inferences about noncompliance. We classify response strategies into three categories, according to their stance toward the violated international regime. *Atonement* strategies accept the regime's fundamental legitimacy and underscore the state's commitment to its international obligations.[8] A government may apologize for its actions (Lind 2011) or specify concrete actions to promote future compliance with the violated rules. For example, when the Swedish government confronted domestic backlash following a 2001 violation of international torture law, leaders adopted an atonement strategy. The government acknowledged responsibility for the violation, apologized, and compensated victims (*Jerusalem Post* 2008).

Disassociation strategies distance the government from the violation in order to reduce perceived responsibility. These strategies are not openly hostile to the regime and may explicitly or implicitly acknowledge the harm caused by noncompliance. However, they seek to narrow a government's liability by arguing that actors without direct responsibility should not be held accountable. A government might protest that the violation was accidental, compelled by extenuating circumstances beyond its control, or caused by the unauthorized actions of low-level actors. An example is the Bush

7. If the initial allegation gets little coverage, a leader may find it strategically advantageous to ignore the event. If a leader expects ongoing news coverage, however, or sees an opportunity to use the crisis as a political tool, we contend that the government will craft some kind of response.

8. This strategy is closely associated with the process of "stigma recognition" (Adler-Nissen 2014; Goffman 1963) in which deviant actors apologize for transgressions and internalize the value judgment of the audience.

administration's response to prisoner abuse at Abu Ghraib prison in Iraq. Political leaders absolved themselves of responsibility, shifting blame to "disgraceful conduct by a few American troops who dishonored our country and disregarded our values" (Goldenberg 2004). Disassociation is a particularly attractive strategy when a previous government has committed the alleged violation, as it allows leaders to enhance their image through an advantageous comparison to a previous government.

Finally, *attack* strategies seek to undermine an international regime's authority and legitimacy. They may involve denying the alleged violation while highlighting bias in institutional decision-making procedures or acknowledging the violation while arguing that the regime is unfair. These strategies frequently employ explicit appeals to national interests. Former US president Trump frequently used attack strategies to criticize the WTO (Carnegie and Carson 2019). Attack strategies are the most confrontational since they challenge the principles on which the regime is built.[9]

Each response strategy is modified to account for the context of a violation. Governments are more constrained when details of the violation cannot be kept secret from the public. This is illustrated by the Iranian government's response to allegations that it shot down a passenger plane in January 2020. The government first denied its involvement in the incident, but as new evidence surfaced, Iranian officials eventually acknowledged responsibility for the incident and apologized, while also blaming "human error" (Fassihi 2020).

Dimensions of government image

Atonement, disassociation, and attack strategies are designed to change how individuals view the government. A government's image, like that of an organization or an individual, is composed of multiple attributes. Citizens form beliefs about political leaders and governments across a range of dimensions, such as whether a leader acts in the best interests of citizens or is competent in executing policy. In countries where significant political power is concentrated in a single executive, beliefs about the leader are often intertwined with general perceptions of the government's performance and competencies.

Adopting a multifaceted view of image sheds light on government incentives and constraints when responding to an allegation of noncompliance. While international relations scholars have long argued that governments accrue a reputation for compliance among other states (Guzman 2008; Keohane 1984; Simmons 2010), domestic audiences are likely to consider this trait as only one aspect of a government's overall performance. The result is a much more complex information environment. International law violations can send multiple signals about a government's underlying traits, and the battle to frame the public's interpretation can magnify, reduce, or completely offset the political costs of noncompliance.

While a government's image could include many aspects of behavior, we draw on work from public administration to highlight four critical dimensions of public image:[10]

Performance. Is the government competent and efficient in its execution of policy?

Morality. Does the government's conduct meet basic ethical standards?

Lawfulness. Does the government abide by legal commitments, rules, and norms?

Allegiance to Citizens. Does the government protect the interests of constituents?

While these dimensions are not exhaustive, they capture key priorities of domestic constituents as they weigh whether to support a political leader. They also consolidate specific government traits like competence (Levendusky and Horowitz 2012; Levy et al. 2015), belligerence (Kertzer and Brutger 2016), and responsibility (Fang 2008) into a single framework.[11] For example, a substantial body of literature has examined how a leader's perceived resolve can affect crisis bargaining (Kertzer 2016; Trachtenberg 2012; Weeks 2008). Kertzer, Renshon, and Yarhi-Milo (2021) find that citizens use capabilities, stakes, signals, and past actions to judge resolve. Combining these insights with our framework suggests that individuals will vary in how much they value resolve and that these underlying differences may affect views of a government's performance and allegiance to citizens. The key insight of this multidimensional approach is that governments can choose which areas to emphasize during a crisis response.

9. By including attack strategies, we extend existing work on legitimation and norm evasion that generally assumes states do not refute the principle of complying (for an exception, see Adler-Nissen [2014] on stigma rejection and counterstigmatization).

10. Our framework is adapted from Carpenter (2010), who cites four elements of a public agency's image: performative, moral, procedural, and technical reputation. See also Carpenter and Krause (2012).

11. For example, we would categorize competence and responsibility as aspects of a government's performative image, while belligerence is related to a government's moral image.

Citizen values and political support

After hearing the government's justification and updating beliefs about its characteristics, citizens decide whether to support or oppose the noncompliant government. To make this decision, they assess the government's image in light of their underlying political values. While the government's image is subject to manipulation, values are fixed in the short term and thus constrain governments as they respond to public relations crises.

Individual values can vary considerably across the public: citizens may disagree about what constitutes honesty (a component of the government's moral image) or competence (a component of performative image). They may also differ in how they prioritize the relative importance of each dimension. This variation means that a shift in a government's image is likely to produce heterogeneous effects on constituent political support.

In portraying political support as jointly determined by a government's image and citizen values, we draw on communications scholarship on image repair. In this tradition, individual attitudes have two components: *beliefs* and *values* (Benoit 2015; Fishbein and Ajzen 2010). Beliefs (image) reflect an individual's understanding of facts. Values determine how individuals evaluate beliefs, which they may view as favorable or unfavorable. The two variables interact to form attitudes. The image repair framework translates readily to electoral politics, where constituents may have the same beliefs about a government but differ in values. For example, two citizens may have identical beliefs about US President Biden's underlying motives on immigration policy but disagree in their evaluation of those motives.

In our theory, individuals evaluate multiple dimensions of a government's image in accordance with their values. Relevant considerations vary by the type of image management threat. For international law violations, we consider an individual's general foreign policy orientation to be a reasonable proxy for relevant underlying values. More specifically, we follow previous research in assuming that individuals have underlying preferences about the importance, effectiveness, and desirability of using military force and that this "hawks/doves" divide will shape citizen assessments of the government's image.[12]

We acknowledge that government rhetoric is sometimes countered by competing narratives from activist groups, opposition parties, or international organizations. These countermessages may mute the impact of the government's image management strategies. However, political leaders maintain a powerful ability to shape narratives on foreign policy issues where they enjoy an informational advantage (Levendusky and Horowitz 2012), particularly when secrecy facilitates the construction of favorable narratives (Carson 2018). We expect the effect of image management to be the largest among the general public and considerably smaller among activists and political elites with hardened views over foreign policy outcomes, although we only probe the former process in our empirical tests.

In summary, image management occurs when governments craft framing strategies to shape their image in the hopes of bolstering political support. Potential government responses to alleged violations (atonement, disassociation, and attack) target different dimensions of the government's image and often entail trade-offs among them. Individual citizens weigh the government's image against their own values and shift support accordingly.

TESTING IMAGE MANAGEMENT

We test how the three response strategies affect a government's image and overall support in an original survey experiment. Our approach builds on recent work leveraging experimental methods to test the effect of international law on public approval (e.g., Chaudoin 2014; Chilton 2014; Powers 2022; Zvobgo 2019). The advantage of a survey experiment is the ability to randomly assign the government's image management technique. If political leaders select response strategies that appeal to their supporters, we will only observe a subset of possible responses in observational data. An experimental setting also allows us to probe how a government's strategy choice interacts with individuals' foreign policy values.

The survey examines how image management shapes public opinion about political leaders. As discussed above, direct electoral pressure is one of two major mechanisms that encourage compliance within international rules. The second mechanism, in which domestic interest groups and civil society organizations mobilize in favor of compliance (Hafner-Burton and Tsutsui 2005; Risse and Sikkink 1999; Simmons 2009), is not tested in the survey experiment. While we assume that domestic public opinion will affect the probability of successful civil society activism, we do not test this empirically and encourage future work to investigate such effects.

Hypotheses

Our theory predicts that noncompliant governments can shape their public image by framing violations in favorable ways. We now specify expectations of how atonement, disassociation, and attack response strategies will affect core

12. For research on foreign policy orientation, see Holsti and Rosenau (1990), Kertzer et al. (2014), and Wittkopf (1990) among others. We examine other measures of citizen values in the appendix.

dimensions of government image. In each case, the counterfactual is a scenario in which the government is accused of noncompliance but does not respond, forgoing the opportunity to engage in image management.

We expect atonement strategies to improve a government's image for lawfulness. These responses acknowledge the legitimacy of international rules and underscore the government's commitment to future compliance. Since they often include an admission of responsibility, we also expect them to enhance a government's moral image (specifically its image for honesty). Yet, an atonement response should diminish a government's image for allegiance to citizen interests, since it explicitly emphasizes the government's commitment to international obligations. We do not have strong ex ante expectations regarding effects on the government's performative image. While admission of fault could lead citizens to infer that leaders are incompetent, others may view atonement as a prudent, instrumental response to protect the country's international reputation.[13]

H1. Atonement responses enhance a noncompliant government's image for lawfulness and morality but diminish its image for allegiance to citizen interests.

Disassociation strategies shift responsibility to other parties. By persuading citizens that the government had no intention to violate international law, these responses should enhance the government's image for lawfulness. When disassociation invokes an accident or unauthorized behavior by government agents, it may have a negative impact on perceptions of government competence—a key element of performance. Effects on morality and allegiance to citizens are unclear, but governments employing a disassociation response may experience a generalized image improvement if citizens attribute the violation to other actors.

H2. Disassociation responses enhance a noncompliant government's image for lawfulness but diminish its image for performance.

We expect attack strategies to bolster a government's image for allegiance to citizen interests. These responses are often explicitly crafted to elevate the national interest over international commitments but with possible negative implications for perceived lawfulness. As with atonement strategies, citizen perceptions of the government's performance and morality could be subject to competing and potentially offsetting pressures.

H3. Attack responses enhance a noncompliant government's image for allegiance to citizen interests but diminish its image for lawfulness.

Finally, we investigate how changes in the government's image affect political support. In general, we expect positive perceptions to translate into greater support from citizens. However, these effects will be conditioned on citizens' foreign policy values. More hawkish individuals are likely to place a higher weight on allegiance to citizen interests compared to their dovish counterparts, making them more responsive to changes in this dimension of government image. Yet, we expect hawkish citizens to respond less favorably to the government's image for lawfulness.

H4. Citizens with hawkish foreign policy values will experience a larger increase in political support when governments improve their image for allegiance, and a smaller increase when governments improve their image for lawfulness.

Survey methodology

We test these hypotheses in a survey fielded in May 2020 to a sample of 2,529 US-based respondents.[14] Respondents are randomly assigned one of three issue areas—torture, trade, or chemical weapons—and provided with background information on the country's international legal commitments. The following text is for the issue area of torture: "The United States is a member of the Convention Against Torture, an international treaty that seeks to promote human rights around the world. Under this agreement, governments pledge that they will abide by a set of rules prohibiting all forms of torture against people residing in their countries. They also agree not to transfer individuals to the custody of other countries where they are likely to be tortured. An international body of experts assesses compliance with the Convention Against Torture's rules."

Respondents then read a hypothetical scenario in which a future US government (in 2025) violates the treaty.[15] In the scenario, an expert review body associated with the treaty determines that the United States has violated international rules. We describe a plausible violation based on the specific

13. Levendusky and Horowitz (2012) find that citizens often forgive a political leader's breach of commitments if they see the action as a prudent response to changed circumstances.

14. Respondents were recruited via Lucid Theorem. See the appendix for sample statistics and survey text.

15. We randomized the political party of the US president in the scenario.

obligations within each treaty. In the torture issue area, the government violates nonrefoulement obligations by transferring an individual to a country where they are subsequently tortured. The trade violation involves the imposition of tariffs on foreign goods. The chemical weapons violation consists of failing to destroy a stockpile of chemical weapons. Respondents are told that the expert body's findings were summarized in a public report, generating a debate about the government's actions.

Respondents are then randomly assigned to a control condition, a comply condition, or one of the three types of image management strategies. We include two versions of the atonement and attack response strategies to examine whether differences within types generate different results. In the main text, we combine these estimates according to the three-category typology presented above (disaggregated estimates are reported in fig. A1). The image management conditions feature an additional US government defense. In the disassociation treatment, for example, respondents learn that the government blames a low-level bureaucrat who was subsequently fired. Text for each treatment is below.

Atonement Response.
Apology: "the US government accepts full responsibility for the violation and apologizes to victimized parties."

Recommitment: "the US government reiterates its support for the agreement and commits to following the rules more closely in the future."

Disassociation Response.
Unauthorized Bureaucrat: "the US government announces the firing of a low-level bureaucrat who failed to follow US policy when committing the violation."

Attack Response.
National Interest Appeal: "the US government argues that its first obligation is to protect US interests, even when it contradicts international law."

Legitimacy Challenge: "the US government argues that the international body has no authority to pass judgment on the United States."

In the control condition, respondents learn about the violation but do not view a response from the US government. We compare control respondents with those in the image management conditions to assess the causal effect of each response strategy. Finally, we further include a comply condition, where the expert review subsequently determines that the US government was in compliance with the agreement. This condition allows us to assess whether compliance always generates the highest level of government support or whether image management strategies can completely eliminate domestic political costs.

After the scenario, we measure respondent beliefs about the four core dimensions of government image. For example, we measure the government's image for allegiance to citizens by having respondents indicate their level of agreement that "the government looks out for the best interests of its citizens."[16] To estimate the government's image for performance, we ask respondents whether it "has the skills to achieve its foreign policy objectives." Moral and lawful image are measured as respondent ratings of the government's honesty and likelihood of repeating violations in the future, respectively.

We measure political support by asking whether respondents would vote for the government in an upcoming election. Respondents select among "definitely vote for," "probably vote for," "probably vote against," and "definitely vote against" the government. For ease of interpretation, we transform the four-point scale of government support to a binary measure that classifies those who will "definitely" and "probably" vote for the government as supporters. Following the first scenario, each respondent is randomly assigned to a second scenario from a different issue area, and the process repeats.[17]

We measure respondents' foreign policy values with a pretreatment questionnaire that estimates their degree of militant internationalism (MI), a common measure of hawkish foreign policy attitudes. We ask the standard battery of questions employed in recent work on citizens' foreign policy orientation (Brutger and Kertzer 2018; Kertzer et al. 2014). Respondents rate their agreement with a series of statements designed to solicit their underlying policy values (e.g., "the US should take all steps including the use of force to prevent aggression by any expansionist power"). We transform responses via principal components analysis and assign respondents a normalized MI score in [0, 1].[18]

16. Respondents rate their agreement with on a five-point scale from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree."

17. The order of the scenarios does not affect the size or nature of the treatment effect.

18. MI is one of several plausible measures of citizen foreign policy values. The appendix reports results using two alternative measures: cooperative internationalism and partisan identification. Additional untested measures like nationalism may also be relevant.

RESULTS

Response strategies and government image

We begin by testing how the image management strategies affect the core dimensions of government image. Figure 2 summarizes the effect of each response strategy on perceptions of the government's morality, lawfulness, allegiance to citizens, and performance. Estimates reflect the difference in respondent ratings between the control group (no government response) and the three treatment categories (atonement, disassociation, and attack responses).

The top panel displays the treatment effect of the atonement response strategy. Consistent with theoretical expectations, governments that employ this strategy significantly increase their image for lawfulness. Respondent expectations of the government's likelihood of future compliance—our measure for lawfulness in the context of international law—increase by nearly half a point on the five-point scale, compared to the control condition. Notably, the atonement treatment reduces the likelihood that respondents assess the government as "extremely" or "somewhat" likely to violate international law in the future from over 60% to 45%. This response strategy also substantially enhances the government's moral image, consistent with hypothesis 1. However, we do not observe the anticipated decline in the government's image for allegiance to citizens. In fact, perceptions of both government allegiance and performance increase in comparison to the control group.[19]

The middle panel shows estimates for the disassociation response strategy. We hypothesized that disassociation should enhance the government's image for lawfulness and diminish its image for performance. Our results provide partial support for hypothesis 2. Disassociation generates a statistically significant increase in respondent perceptions of government lawfulness, although the strategy is substantively less effective than atonement in this regard. It also bolsters the government's image across the other three dimensions. It appears that the disassociation response is successful in diffusing blame in a general matter, reducing a range of negative inferences that citizens would otherwise associate with noncompliance.

Finally, the bottom panel presents effects of the attack response strategy. Results differ dramatically from the previous two strategies in two ways. Attack is uniquely effective at enhancing the government's image for allegiance to citizens, increasing respondent perceptions on this dimension by approximately 0.4 points. However, the strategy comes with a stark trade-off: the government's image for lawfulness declines compared to the control condition. These results are consistent with hypothesis 3. Attack responses also increase perceptions of government honesty compared to the control condition. The estimated effect on perceived government performance is positive but insignificant at the .05 level ($p = .063$). Disaggregating results by the two versions of attack strategies reveals that appeals to the national interest outperform legitimacy challenges in enhancing the government's image for morality and allegiance to citizen interests (see fig. A1).

The differences in effects across strategies underscore that governments face trade-offs when minimizing political fallout from international law violations. Image management clearly shifts beliefs among respondents, but strategies vary in how they affect different beliefs. Atonement responses are the most effective at persuading citizens that the government will fulfill its legal obligations in the future, while attack responses optimize beliefs that the government has citizens' best interests at heart. Disassociation has a moderate, generalized effect across all four dimensions of government image.

To gauge whether treatment effects differ across the issue areas of torture, trade, and chemical weapons, we report separate estimates for each in figure A2. The effects of image management strategies are highly consistent across these diverse policy domains. Only atonement exhibits some weak evidence of heterogeneous effects: it is marginally more effective at increasing perceptions of government honesty in the wake of chemical weapons violations, compared to trade violations ($p = .10$).

While each response strategy enhances at least one dimension of government image, the best case scenario for a government is the comply condition, in which respondents are told that a subsequent expert review determines the government did not violate the international rule (see fig. A3). This result suggests that even if governments can use image management strategies to mitigate the costs of violations, they still have political incentives to comply with international commitments. Governments weigh many factors, however, when calculating compliance decisions, and once a violation has occurred, this option is no longer available to them.[20]

Foreign policy values and political support

Our theory suggests that citizens' foreign policy values will condition the effect of the government's image on domestic political support. We now examine this second causal arrow

19. Figure A1 reports separate estimates for the two versions of atonement strategy; while most effects are very similar, the addition of an apology creates a substantially larger increase in the government's moral image.

20. We also note that the design of the comply condition may inflate its effect, since the exoneration of the government after an initial accusation of noncompliance may constitute a distinct "vindication" effect.

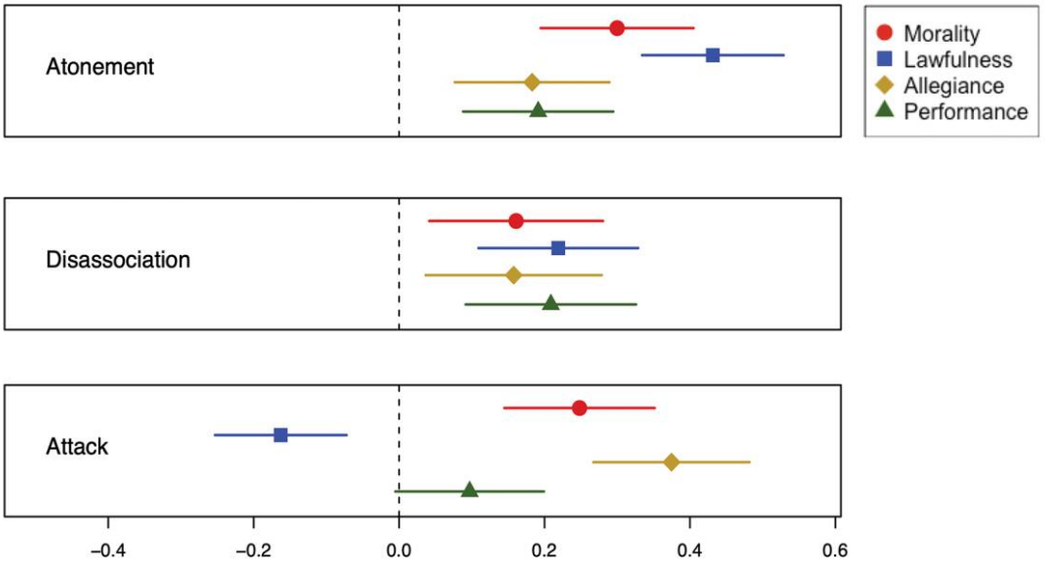

Figure 2. Treatment effect of each image management strategy on the four dimensions of government image, compared to the control condition (international law violation with no government response). Point estimates and 95% confidence intervals are displayed for each treatment.

in figure 1. Because citizen values determine the relative weight attached to the government's image, values will interact with image to determine support for the incumbent government.

In our main specification, we proxy foreign policy values with MI, a composite measure of hawkish attitudes. In hypothesis 4, we hypothesized that hawkish individuals (i.e., those with high MI scores) are more likely to support governments with a strong image for allegiance to citizens compared to low-MI individuals. We expect the opposite relationship with respect to the government's image for lawfulness.

To test these expectations, we analyze how each of the four image components interacts with MI to predict government support. We estimate a series of linear probability models to assess how a respondent's likelihood of voting for the government responds to the government's image and the respondent's foreign policy orientation. The coefficients on the interaction terms indicate whether individuals with more hawkish preferences prioritize different elements of government image in their vote choice. Unlike in the experimental tests above, we are unable to randomly distribute MI scores or perceptions of the government's image among respondents. As a result, these tests can establish correlations consistent with our theoretical mechanism, but they are not causally identified.

Our results suggest that citizens weigh the multiple dimensions of government image on the basis of individual values. Each element of image is a significant predictor of respondent support for the government in a hypothetical election. But there are meaningful differences in the way hawkish and dovish citizens evaluate the dimensions of image. Specifically, hawkish respondents (i.e., those with high MI scores) are substantially less likely to reward governments with an image for morality and lawfulness.

Figure 3 plots the effect of increasing the government's image for morality and lawfulness as a citizen's MI score increases. We report the full regression results in table A2. The other two elements of government image—performance and allegiance—do not strongly interact with MI. We therefore find mixed support for hypothesis 4.[21]

Together, these findings suggest that government strategies may themselves generate heterogeneous effects among citizens with different value structures. By maximizing some elements of image at the expense of others, the response strategies will vary in their appeal to different constituents. We examine this in figure A5, which displays separate treatment effects of the original response strategies for "hawks" and "doves."[22] Compared to hawks, doves respond more favorably to atonement responses and the compliance condition.

21. In tables A3 and A4, we repeat these analyses with two other potential measures of citizen values: cooperative internationalism and partisan identification. We find no evidence that cooperative foreign policy values condition the effect of government image on vote choice. The effects of party ID are similar to MI: Republicans are less likely to reward a government image for morality and lawfulness, compared to Democrats.

22. Here, we define hawks as respondents who score above the 75th percentile on MI, and doves as those who score below the 25th percentile.

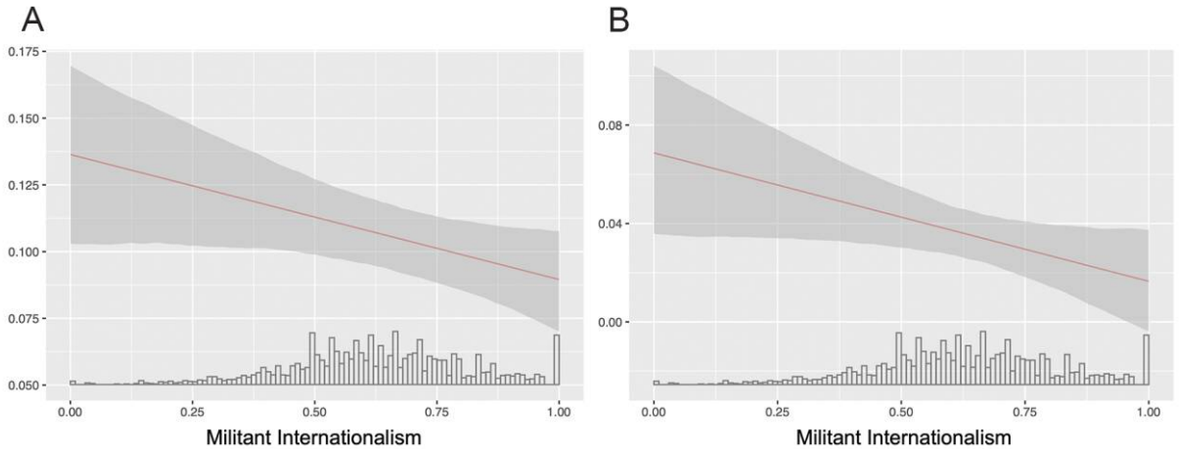

Figure 3. Interactive effects of government image and militant internationalism: estimated effect of a 1-unit increase in the government's moral (*A*) and lawful (*B*) image on the likelihood that respondents support the government in a hypothetical election. In both panels, estimated support decreases with militant internationalism (*X*-axis). Estimates and 95% confidence intervals are derived from models 2 and 3 in table A2.

The finding that citizens differ in their evaluation of government image is significant because it is likely to shape how governments select specific image management strategies. A government's political coalition is not a random sample from the general population. Some leaders, for example, may rely on particularly hawkish citizens, donors, or interest groups for political support. During a political crisis, they are likely to choose strategies that appeal to these core supporters. This constrains their freedom to employ strategies like atonement, even if doing so serves broader foreign policy goals.

CONCLUSION

Both international rules and violations are subject to significant interpretational ambiguity. We theorize that how a government responds to an alleged violation of international law is part of a larger strategy of image management. Governments use accusations to shape citizen beliefs' about different aspects of their character and abilities. Drawing from scholarship on public relations and corporate communication, we conceptualize a government's image as composed of four primary traits: moral authority, performance, lawfulness, and allegiance to citizen interests. We argue that policy makers face trade-offs in improving different characteristics and are also constrained by the underlying values of their supporters.

Our results, drawn from a survey experiment, shed new light on the link between international law and domestic politics. Image management can take many different forms, and each distinct response strategy is likely to affect a government's image in different ways. By highlighting the causal chain between response strategy, government image, citizen values, and political support, we illustrate why international law violations can become politically salient, even when the issue at hand might be removed from the everyday lives of citizens. Alleged violations are political opportunities for governments to shape their image with supporters.

Our article opens a promising new agenda for additional research. Future work should test the effect of image management strategies in the context of multiple competing messages by the government and opposition parties, civil society organizations, or international organizations. Additional theoretical development is needed to unpack how our observed public opinion effects might interact with other mechanisms of domestic political pressure such as activist mobilization. Finally, scholars of international cooperation can examine how image management strategies shape the resilience and perceived legitimacy of international regimes.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

We are grateful to Ryan Brutger, Susan Hyde, Amanda Kennard, Robert Keohane, Bronwyn Leebaw, Lauren Peritz, Paul Poast, Christina Schneider, Arthur Stein, Erik Voeten, and participants of the 2019 and 2020 University of California Conference on International Cooperation for feedback on parts of this project and to Guo Chen, Renaud Concordet, Rhiana Ferguson, Jever Mariwala, Nora Patterson, and Dana Sinclair for their research assistance. Portions of this research project were presented at the American Political Science Association conference in 2017 and 2019 and the International Political Economy Society conference in 2018.

REFERENCES

Adler-Nissen, Rebecca. 2014. "Stigma Management in International Relations: Transgressive Identities, Norms, and Order in International Society." *International Organization* 68 (1): 143–76.

Benoit, William L. 2014. "Image Repair Theory in the Context of Strategic Communication." In Derina Holtzhausen and Ansgar Zerfass, eds.,

The Routledge Handbook of Strategic Communication. New York: Routledge.

Benoit, William L. 2015. *Accounts, Excuses, and Apologies: Image Repair Theory and Research*. 2nd ed. Albany, NY: SUNY Press.

Bowcott, Owen, Oliver Holmes, and Erin Durkin. 2018. "John Bolton Threatens War Crimes Court with Sanctions in Virulent Attack." *Guardian*, September 10.

Brutger, Ryan. 2021. "The Power of Compromise: Proposal Power, Partisanship, and Public Support in International Bargaining." *World Politics* 73 (1): 128–66.

Brutger, Ryan, and Josh Kertzer. 2018. "A Dispositional Theory of Reputation Costs." *International Organization* 72 (3): 693–724.

Bull, Hedley. 1977. *The Anarchical Society: A Study of Order in World Politics*. London: Macmillan International Higher Education.

Búzás, Zoltán I. 2018. "Is the Good News about Law Compliance Good News about Norm Compliance? The Case of Racial Equality." *International Organization* 72 (2): 351–85.

Carnegie, Allison, and Austin Carson. 2018. "The Spotlight's Harsh Glare: Rethinking Publicity and International Order." *International Organization* 72 (3): 627–57.

Carnegie, Allison, and Austin Carson. 2019. "Reckless Rhetoric? Compliance Pessimism and International Order in the Age of Trump." *Journal of Politics* 81 (2): 739–46.

Carpenter, Daniel. 2010. *Reputation and Power: Organizational Image and Pharmaceutical Regulation at the FDA*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Carpenter, Daniel P., and George A. Krause. 2012. "Reputation and Public Administration." *Public Administration Review* 72 (1): 26–32.

Carson, Austin. 2018. *Secret Wars*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Chaudoin, Stephen. 2014. "Promises or Policies? An Experimental Analysis of International Agreements and Audience Reactions." *International Organization* 68 (1): 235–56.

Chaudoin, Stephen. 2016. "How Contestation Moderates the Effects of International Institutions: The International Criminal Court and Kenya." *Journal of Politics* 78 (2): 557–71.

Chilton, Adam S. 2014. "The Influence of International Human Rights Agreements on Public Opinion: An Experimental Study." *Chicago Journal of International Law* 15:110–37.

Chilton, Adam S., and Mila Versteeg. 2016. "International Law, Constitutional Law, and Public Support for Torture." *Research and Politics* 3 (1): 2053168016636413.

Chong, Dennis, and James N. Druckman. 2007. "Framing Public Opinion in Competitive Democracies." *American Political Science Review* 101 (4): 637–55.

Chu, Jonathan A. 2019. "A Clash of Norms? How Reciprocity and International Humanitarian Law Affect American Opinion on the Treatment of POWs." *Journal of conflict resolution* 63 (5): 1140–64.

Cooley, Alexander, and Jack Snyder. 2015. *Ranking the World: Grading States as a Tool of Global Governance*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Crawford, Vincent P., and Joel Sobel. 1982. "Strategic Information Transmission." *Econometrica: Journal of the Econometric Society* 50 (6): 1431–51.

Dai, Xinyuan. 2007. *International Institutions and National Policies*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

DeYoung, Karen, and Carol Morello. 2020. "Trump Authorizes Sanctions Targeting International Criminal Court." *Washington Post*, June 11. https://www.washingtonpost.com/national-security/trump-authorizes-sanctions-targeting-international-criminal-court/2020/06/11/6130d78c-abf4-11ea-9063-e69bd6520940_story.html.

Downs, George W., and Michael A. Jones. 2002. "Reputation, Compliance, and International Law." *Journal of Legal Studies* 31 (January): S95–S114.

Downs, George W., and David M. Rocke. 1995. *Optimal Imperfection? Domestic Uncertainty and Institutions in International Relations*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Druckman, James N. 2001. "The Implications of Framing Effects for Citizen Competence." *Political Behavior* 23 (3): 225–56.

Entman, Robert M. 1993. "Framing: Toward Clarification of a Fractured Paradigm." *Journal of Communication* 43 (4): 51–58.

Fang, Songying. 2008. "The Informational Role of International Institutions and Domestic Politics." *American Journal of Political Science* 52 (2): 304–21.

Fassihi, Farnaz. 2020. "Anatomy of a Lie: How Iran Covered Up the Downing of an Airliner." *New York Times*, January 26. https://www.nytimes.com/2020/01/26/world/middleeast/iran-plane-crash-coverup.html (accessed June 19, 2020).

Fearon, James D. 1994. "Domestic Political Audiences and the Escalation of International Disputes." *American Political Science Review* 88 (3): 577–92.

Fishbein, Martin, and Icek Ajzen. 2010. *Predicting and Changing Behavior: The Reasoned Action Approach*. London: Psychology.

Goddard, Stacie E. 2015. "The Rhetoric of Appeasement: Hitler's Legitimation and British Foreign Policy, 1938–39." *Security Studies* 24 (1): 95–130.

Goddard, Stacie E., and Ronald R. Krebs. 2015. "Rhetoric, Legitimation, and Grand Strategy." *Security Studies* 24 (1): 5–36.

Goffman, Erving. 1963. *Stigma: Notes on the Management of Spoiled Identity*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

Goldenberg, Suzanee. 2004. "US to Demolish Abu Ghraib Jail and Punish Its General." *Guardian*, May 25. https://www.theguardian.com/world/2004/may/25/usa.iraq2 (accessed June 22, 2020).

Guisinger, Alexandra, and Elizabeth N. Saunders. 2017. "Mapping the Boundaries of Elite Cues: How Elites Shape Mass Opinion across International Issues." *International Studies Quarterly* 61 (2): 425–41.

Guzman, Andrew T. 2008. *How International Law Works: A Rational Choice Theory*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Hafner-Burton, Emilie M., and Kiyoteru Tsutsui. 2005. "Human Rights in a Globalizing World: The Paradox of Empty Promises." *American Journal of Sociology* 110 (5): 1373–411.

Holsti, Ole R., and James N. Rosenau. 1990. "The Structure of Foreign Policy Attitudes among American Leaders." *Journal of Politics* 52 (1): 94–125.

Jerusalem Post. 2008. "Sweden Pays 502,000 in Compensation to Exonerated Terror Suspect." *Jerusalem Post*, July 4. https://www.jpost.com/International/Sweden-pays-502000-in-compensation-to-exonerated-terror-suspect (accessed on June 22, 2020).

Keck, Margaret E., and Kathryn Sikkink. 1998. *Activists beyond Borders: Advocacy Networks in International Politics*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Kelley, Judith G. 2017. *Scorecard Diplomacy: Grading States to Influence Their Reputation and Behavior*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Kelley, Judith G., and Beth A. Simmons. 2015. "Politics by Number: Indicators as Social Pressure in International Relations." *American Journal of Political Science* 59 (1): 55–70.

Keohane, Robert. 1984. *After Hegemony: Cooperation and Discord in the World Political Economy*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Kertzer, Joshua D. 2016. *Resolve in International Politics*, vol. 2. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Kertzer, Joshua D., and Ryan Brutger. 2016. "Decomposing Audience Costs: Bringing the Audience Back into Audience Cost Theory." *American Journal of Political Science* 60 (1): 234–49.

Kertzer, Joshua D., Kathleen E. Powers, Brian C. Rathbun, and Ravi Iyer. 2014. "Moral Support: How Moral Values Shape Foreign Policy Attitudes." *Journal of Politics* 76 (3): 825–40.

Kertzer, Joshua D., Jonathan Renshon, and Keren Yarhi-Milo. 2021. "How Do Observers Assess Resolve?" *British Journal of Political Science* 51 (1): 308–30.

Kim, Matthew D. 2019a. "Public and Elite Opinion on International Human Rights Law: Completing the Causal Chain of the Domestic Compliance Mechanism." *Journal of Human Rights* 18 (4): 419–38.

Kim, Matthew D. 2019b. "Reputation and Compliance with International Human Rights Law: Experimental Evidence from the US and South Korea." *Journal of East Asian Studies* 19 (2): 215–38.

Kratochwil, Friedrich, and John Gerard Ruggie. 1986. "International Organization: A State of the Art on an Art of the State." *International Organization* 40 (4): 753–75.

Krebs, Ronald R. 2015. "Tell Me a Story: FDR, Narrative, and the Making of the Second World War." *Security Studies* 24 (1): 131–70.

Kreps, Sarah E., and Geoffrey P. R. Wallace. 2016. "International Law, Military Effectiveness, and Public Support for Drone Strikes." *Journal of Peace Research* 53 (6): 830–44.

Levendusky, Matthew S., and Michael C. Horowitz. 2012. "When Backing Down Is the Right Decision: Partisanship, New Information, and Audience Costs." *Journal of Politics* 74 (2): 323–38.

Levy, Jack S., Michael K. McKoy, Paul Poast, and Geoffrey P. R. Wallace. 2015. "Backing out or Backing In? Commitment and Consistency in Audience Costs Theory." *American Journal of Political Science* 59 (4): 988–1001.

Lind, Jennifer. 2011. *Sorry States: Apologies in International Politics*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Lupu, Yonatan, and Geoffrey P. R. Wallace. 2019. "Violence, Nonviolence, and the Effects of International Human Rights Law." *American Journal of Political Science* 63 (2): 411–26.

Mercer, Jonathan. 1996. *Reputation and International Politics*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Minozzi, William. 2011. "A Jamming Theory of Politics." *Journal of Politics* 73 (2): 301–15.

Minozzi, William, and Jonathan Woon. 2016. "Competition, Preference Uncertainty, and Jamming: A Strategic Communication Experiment." *Games and Economic Behavior* 96:97–114.

Morrow, James D. 2007. "When Do States Follow the Laws of War?" *American Political Science Review* 101 (3): 559–72.

Morse, Julia C. 2019. "Blacklists, Market Enforcement, and the Global Regime to Combat Terrorist Financing." *International Organization* 73 (3): 511–45.

Morse, Julia C. 2022. *The Bankers' Blacklist: Unofficial Market Enforcement and the Global Fight against Illicit Financing*. Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press.

Powers, Ryan. 2022. "Is Context Pretext? Domestic Audiences and the Situational Politics of Non-compliance." Working paper.

Rathbun, Brian C. 2012. *Trust in International Cooperation*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Rathbun, Brian C., Joshua D. Kertzer, Jason Reifler, Paul Goren, and Thomas J. Scotto. 2016. Taking Foreign Policy Personally: Personal Values and Foreign Policy Attitudes. *International Studies Quarterly* 60:124–37.

Rathbun, Brian C., and Rachel Stein. 2020. "Greater Goods: Morality and Attitudes toward the Use of Nuclear Weapons." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 64 (5): 787–816.

Raustiala, Kal. 1997. "States, NGOs, and International Environmental Institutions." *International Studies Quarterly* 41:719–40.

Risse, Thomas, and Kathryn Sikkink. 1999. "The Socialization of International Human Rights Norms into Domestic Practices: Introduction." In Thomas Risse, Stephen C. Ropp, and Kathryn Sikkink, eds., *The Power of Human Rights International Norms and Domestic Change*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Rosendorff, B. Peter, and Helen V. Milner. 2001. "The Optimal Design of International Trade Institutions: Uncertainty and Escape." *International Organization* 55 (4): 829–57.

Sanders, Rebecca. 2011. "(Im)plausible Legality: The Rationalisation of Human Rights Abuses in the American 'Global War on Terror.'" *International Journal of Human Rights* 15 (4): 605–26.

Shane, Scott. 2012. "No Charges Filed on Harsh Tactics Used by the CIA." *New York Times*, August 30. https://www.nytimes.com/2012/08/31/us/holder-rules-out-prosecutions-in-cia-interrogations.html.

Simmons, Beth A. 2009. *Mobilizing for Human Rights: International Law in Domestic Politics*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Simmons, Beth A. 2010. "Treaty Compliance and Violation." *Annual Review of Political Science* 13:273–96.

Smith, Alastair. 1998. "International Crises and Domestic Politics." *American Political Science Review* 92 (3): 623–38.

Strezhnev, Anton, Beth A. Simmons, and Matthew D. Kim. 2019. "Rulers or Rules? International Law, Elite Cues and Public Opinion." *European Journal of International Law* 30 (4): 1281–302.

Terman, Rochelle, and Erik Voeten. 2018. "The Relational Politics of Shame: Evidence from the Universal Periodic Review." *Review of International Organizations* 13 (1): 1–23.

Tomz, Michael. 2007a. "Domestic Audience Costs in International Relations: An Experimental Approach." *International Organization* 61(4): 821–40.

Tomz, Michael. 2007b. *Reputation and International Cooperation: Sovereign Debt across Three Centuries*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Trachtenberg, Marc. 2012. "Audience Costs: An Historical Analysis." *Security Studies* 12 (1): 3–42.

Trager, Robert F., and Lynn Vavreck. 2011. "The Political Costs of Crisis Bargaining: Presidential Rhetoric and the Role of Party." *American Journal of Political Science* 55 (3): 526–45.

Von Stein, Jana. 2008. "The International Law and Politics of Climate Change: Ratification of the United Nations Framework Convention and the Kyoto Protocol." *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 52 (2): 243–68.

Wallace, Geoffrey P. R. 2013. "International Law and Public Attitudes toward Torture: An Experimental Study." *International Organization* 67 (1): 105–40.

Weeks, Jessica. 2008. "Autocratic Audience Costs: Regime Type and Signaling Resolve." *International Organization* 62 (1): 35–64.

Wittkopf, Eugene R. 1990. *Faces of Internationalism: Public Opinion and American Foreign Policy*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Yu, Mo. 2020. "US Officials, Lawmakers Blast WTO Ruling on US Tariffs on China." *Voice of America*, September 16. https://www.voanews.com/economy-business/us-officials-lawmakers-blast-wto-ruling-us-tariffs-china.

Zvobgo, Kelebogile. 2019. "Human Rights versus National Interests: Shifting US Public Attitudes on the International Criminal Court." *International Studies Quarterly* 63 (4): 1065–78.